

A BOOK OF TASTE / III

The Patisserie of the Unconscious

Napoleon

CELEBRATION



*Sometimes love is measured in the number of
layers.*

HISTORY / 01

The Thousand Leaves

18th — 19th century · France



The cake descends from the French mille-feuille — the 'thousand leaves' — thin sheets of puff pastry layered with pastry cream.

It was a confectioner's showpiece: precise, patient, and built from almost nothing but butter, flour and time.

HISTORY / 02

A Cake Named Napoleon

1912 · Moscow



For the centenary of the 1812 victory over Napoleon, Moscow's bakers cut the mille-feuille into small triangles resembling the emperor's cocked hat.

The joke stuck. A French pastry, renamed for a defeated French general, entered Russian life for good.

HISTORY / 03

The Holiday You Built

Soviet decades · The Soviet home



In the Soviet kitchen the Napoleon became a cake you assembled over two days. Butter was queued for; layers were rolled late into the night.

Scarcity turned dessert into an act of devotion. You could not simply buy the holiday — you made it, one thin layer at a time.

HISTORY / 04

The Family Notebook

Passed by hand · From mother to daughter



The recipe travelled in handwritten notebooks, from mother to daughter and neighbour to neighbour, each hand adjusting it slightly.

Left to rest until morning, the strict layers softened into one tender whole — patience and love pressed into a single slice.

AFTERTASTE

*A cake had become a way of
keeping a family together.*

A SMALL PRACTICE

Create one celebration by hand. Not because it is efficient, but because making something slowly can itself become the event.

*Whose labour made celebration feel effortless to
you?*

RECIPE / INGREDIENTS

Home-Style Napoleon Cake

A home-adapted version built on ready puff pastry.

- 500 g puff pastry
- 500 ml milk
- 3 egg yolks
- 120 g sugar
- 40 g cornstarch
- 1 tsp vanilla extract
- 150 g butter
- pinch of salt



RECIPE / METHOD

- 01 Bake the puff pastry in thin sheets until golden.
 - 02 Heat most of the milk.
 - 03 Whisk yolks, sugar, cornstarch, salt, and remaining milk.
 - 04 Slowly add the warm milk.
 - 05 Cook on low heat until thick.
 - 06 Add vanilla and cool slightly.
 - 07 Beat in the butter.
 - 08 Layer pastry and cream.
 - 09 Cover with pastry crumbs.
 - 10 Chill overnight.
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The Napoleon is only pastry and cream, but its patience is the whole point — the waiting is the recipe.